

Draft - expert review pending

This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but no reviewer has read it yet. Treat its sources and claims with care.

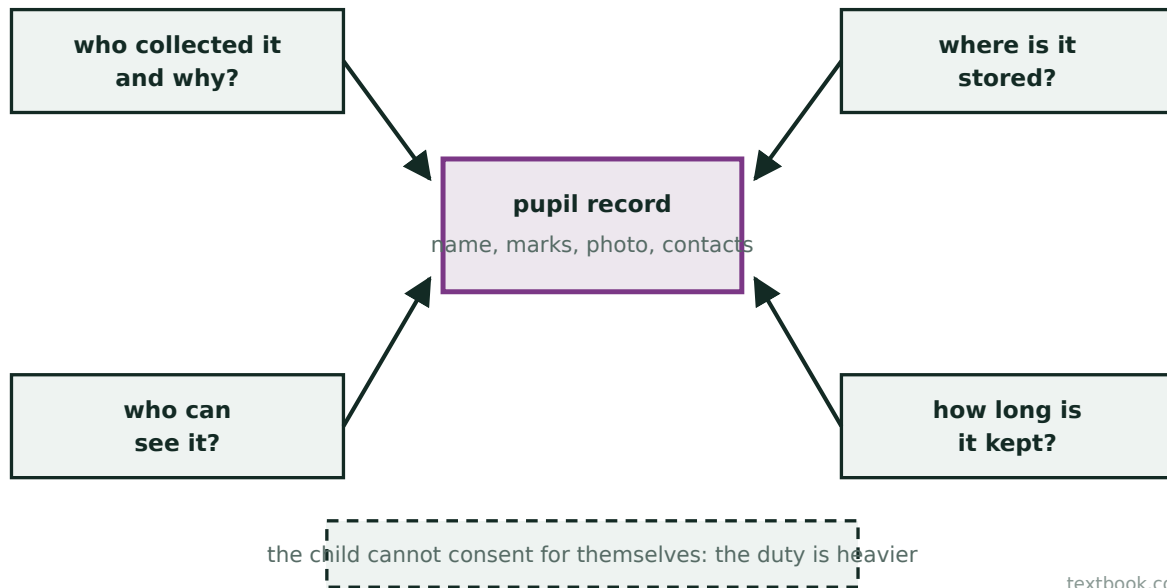
Topic 4.4 - Privacy and data protection

A real classroom situation

A vendor visits a school in Hyderabad offering a "free" pupil-learning app. To set it up, he asks for the full names, ages, photographs, parent phone numbers and home addresses of every pupil in Class 6 - about forty children. The head teacher, who has read nothing about data protection, hands over the register. Nobody signs anything. Nobody asks where the data will live, who else will see it, or what happens to it when the vendor's company closes. The children, whose data it is, are never asked at all. This topic gives you the questions the head teacher should have asked - and the habit of asking them before the register leaves the room.

Four questions for any pupil record

Personal data belongs to the person it describes; the school is a caretaker



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Explanation

Privacy and data protection

Personal data is any information that identifies a living person: name, photograph, phone number, address, marks, health notes, biometric fingerprints. Some of it is sensitive

- data whose leakage harms more than embarrasses: health records, religion, biometrics, financial details. A school is one of the richest personal-data holders in any community: it holds children's identities, addresses, photographs, results, and often family circumstances, for years.

The core idea of data protection is that personal data belongs to the person it describes, not to whoever happens to hold it. A school is a caretaker, not an owner. From that one idea come the questions every collection must survive.

Why is this data being collected, and is the purpose legitimate and specific - or is it "we might need it someday"? **Where** will it be stored, on whose machines, and under whose protection? **Who** can see it, inside the school and outside it? **How long** will it be kept, and what happens to it after? And for children

especially: their consent cannot be assumed, because a child cannot weigh consequences the way an adult can - the duty on the school is therefore heavier, not lighter.

School data: who may ask, and what duty it carries

Data a school holds	Who may ask for it	Handling duty
pupil names and marks	the school and education authorities	access limited to staff who need it
pupil photographs	the school, with parent permission	never published without consent
parent contact numbers	the school, for its own use	not shared with vendors or apps
staff records	the school administration	kept secure, minimal copies
health or biometric notes	the school and health professionals	sensitive data: strictest handling

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Pakistan's legal backdrop is still developing: the Prevention of Electronic Crimes Act 2016 criminalises unauthorised access to and copying of data, and the National Cyber Security Policy 2021 commits the country to protecting citizens' information systems (Ministry of IT and Telecommunication, 2021); a dedicated personal-data-protection law remains under discussion. That gap makes habits matter more, not less: a school that waits for a statute before respecting its pupils' data has already failed them.

The practical habits for a teacher are small and real. Collect the minimum: if the app needs given names to greet a child, it does not need home addresses. Prefer paper kept in a locked cupboard to spreadsheets forwarded on chat. Photograph pupils only with permission and never publish their images with their names. Do not use personal accounts and phones to hold class data longer than the task needs. And when a vendor asks - ask the four questions, in writing, before the register moves.

Activity: The vendor visit role-play

Work in groups of four. About 20 minutes.

1. Roles: the vendor, the head teacher, a class teacher, and a parent who happens to be present. The vendor offers a free learning app and asks for the Class 6 register (names, ages, photographs, parent numbers, addresses).
2. Play the scene once as written - with the head teacher's likely instinct to agree.
3. Then replay it with the class teacher armed with the four questions (why, where, who, how long) and the child-consent concern. Let the vendor improvise answers.
4. As a group, write the school's rule in two sentences: what must be asked before any pupil data leaves the school, and what answer must be refused.

Check your understanding

1. Define personal data and give one example of data that is sensitive.
(Remember)
2. Name the four questions any collection of personal data must survive.
(Remember)
3. The app vendor asks for home addresses but the app works without them. Using the collect-the-minimum principle, state what you would give and justify it. (Apply)
4. Explain why a child's consent to data collection cannot be treated like an adult's. (Understand)

Summary

Personal data belongs to the person it describes; schools are caretakers of a community's richest data, most of it about children who cannot consent for themselves. Every collection must survive four questions - why, where, who, how long - and the collect-the-minimum habit answers most dilemmas before

they arise. Pakistan's legal protections are developing, which makes the school's own discipline the real protection.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can define personal data and sensitive data with school examples.
- ☐ I can ask the four questions of any proposed data collection.
- ☐ I can apply collect-the-minimum to a described request.

Try this at your practicum school

List the kinds of personal data you saw being handled in one school day (registers, notes, photos, messages). For each, note where it was kept and who could see it. Bring the list back - it becomes Unit 5's ethics discussion material.

Summative task

Write a one-page data-protection plan for your practicum school: the five kinds of data it holds, where each currently lives (your observation), the riskiest current practice, and three rules you would introduce first. Connect one rule to a threat from Topic 4.1 and one to the vendor scenario.

Marking guide (10 marks):

- The data inventory is concrete and complete: 3 marks.
- The riskiest practice identified with its actual harm path (Analyse): 3 marks.
- Three rules are actionable and one is tied to a named threat: 3 marks.
- Clear, one page: 1 mark.

Further reading

- Ministry of Information Technology and Telecommunication. (2021). *National Cyber Security Policy*. Government of Pakistan. <https://moitt.gov.pk/>

- Bourgeois, D. T., Smith, J. L., Wang, S., & Mortati, J. (2019). *Information Systems for Business and Beyond* (2nd ed.), chapter 6. Open Textbook Library. <https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/information-systems-for-business-and-beyond>
- Stair, R., & Reynolds, G. *Principles of Information Systems*. Cengage Learning. (Course guide reading; print monograph, cited at bibliographic level.)

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback